

Chapter 21_4 - Beauty

The door closed, and the corridor's dimness enveloped her entire body. Chu Qingqiu looked at the figures inside the room and sighed silently, then stepped toward the neighboring room.

How could she not see through that little demon's scheming? But what could she do about it?

When she spoke up, she had to go through fire and water.

A strange fragrance flowed from the door crack. After holding her breath, Chu Qingqiu raised her hand to knock. In less than a moment, the door creaked open, and a woman's soft arm extended from inside, hooking around her arm.

"Why did you take so long to come, young master? This humble servant has grown tired from waiting." The woman pulled hard, and Chu Qingqiu followed her force and walked in. The door creaked shut again.

The interior decor had been clearly seen earlier. Chu Qingqiu didn't look around again, but silently followed the woman's steps, being supported as she sat down on the beauty couch.

The couch was covered with snow-white fur, soft as clouds to the touch.

"Come, this humble servant toasts you a cup, young master." The woman's phoenix eyes looked Chu Qingqiu up and down, unable to resist reaching out to touch her cheek, but Chu Qingqiu tilted her head to avoid it.

"Oh, still an innocent one¹." The woman smiled even more happily, her red lips curving to her ears. She picked up a wine cup from the table and forcibly placed it in Chu Qingqiu's hands. "Our Ruyan Tower often has guests, but we've never had one as handsome as you, young master."

The woman seemed very taken with her, pressing her entire body against Chu Qingqiu's, drinking the wine in her own hands with seductive eyes.

Chu Qingqiu gently closed her eyes, suppressing the urge to push her away, and picked up the wine cup, pretending to drink.

"Is there only you in this Ruyan Tower?" Chu Qingqiu set down the wine cup, trying to keep some distance from her, and spoke coldly.

"What, am I alone not enough? What need is there for others?" The woman spoke coquettishly. Every sentence she spoke seemed to carry hooks, and each time she opened her mouth, it made one's heart itch.

Except for Chu Qingqiu, who only felt like ants were crawling all over her body, disgusting her terribly.

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu didn't respond, the woman could only pout charmingly and put down her cup: "There are others. Whatever type you want, young master - playful ones, beautiful ones - I have portraits here. You can pick through them one by one."

With that, she stood up and took a stack of papers from the table, placing them in Chu Qingqiu's hands.

The women in the paintings were indeed of various types, all national beauties, but something seemed strange about them. Chu Qingqiu stared at two portraits for a while before discovering the peculiarity.

Although all the people looked different, their expressions were exactly the same.

She calmly flipped through them and finally found the birthmark Ning Fuyi had mentioned on the forehead of the last portrait.

"Her." Chu Qingqiu pulled out that portrait and placed it on the table.

"This..." The woman pulled out a handkerchief from somewhere, wringing it in both hands with a troubled expression. "This girl only came last night. She doesn't understand anything yet..."

"No matter. I want her." Chu Qingqiu said decisively.

The woman had no choice but to compromise. She stood up and opened the door, saying something to someone outside, then gracefully returned to sit beside Chu Qingqiu, leaning against her arm: "Please wait, young master. She just arrived and hasn't bathed yet. I've already had someone take her to dress up and put on makeup."

The woman seemed extremely fond of Chu Qingqiu, her eyes constantly glancing at her. She suddenly blew out the candles and placed her hand on Chu Qingqiu's shoulder.

Chu Qingqiu immediately stood up, avoiding her touch. But as soon as she stood, she suddenly felt weakness in her limbs and hurriedly supported herself against the table edge, greatly alarmed.

Logically, even though she had lost half her cultivation now, she absolutely wouldn't miss any magical arts. But she had never sensed anything wrong, so how could she now...

Seeing this, the woman smiled broadly. She slowly stood up, acting like a delicate maiden, and reached for Chu Qingqiu's sleeve: "Don't be afraid, young master. This humble servant won't harm you. Who told you to have such a beautiful face? This humble servant doesn't want to hand you over to others."

When the woman came closer, one could see that those originally ordinary eyes now had four-petaled flower-like patterns in them.

"Fox clan²." Chu Qingqiu suddenly understood, thinking to herself. She waved her hand to pull her sleeve from the woman's palm and staggered backward.

She had been careless. In the past, she cultivated the emotionless way³, and such tricks were mere child's play to her. But now...

The woman covered her lips and approached step by step, looking up close to Chu Qingqiu: "My tricks don't work on those with pure hearts and clear six senses⁴. Young master, you have knots in your heart, and they're quite heavy."

As she spoke, her finger was about to touch Chu Qingqiu's chest. The scenery before Chu Qingqiu's eyes suddenly changed, and the woman's appearance was replaced by another person - phoenix eyes curved with mischief, looking at her with an air of wickedness.

"Chu Qingqiu, you have such a day too." That person laughed heartily at the gloomy sky, the Emei spike⁵ in her hand gleaming coldly as it slid across her neck, leaving a crimson bloodstain.

Then suddenly, that person changed expression. Her finger lifted Chu Qingqiu's chin, and blood-red lips suddenly approached, so close that with just one movement, their lips and teeth could touch.

At the same time, on the other side of the wall, Liu Wenzhu's expression suddenly changed. She anxiously pulled at Ning Fuyi: "Yiyi, I feel something's wrong. Why isn't the Divine Venerable moving?"

Ning Fuyi naturally noticed too. She put away her spectating mood, her brow furrowing tighter as she stared at the scene behind the wall.

Chu Qingqiu retreated step by step, her beautiful brows knitted together as if struggling with something. Her slender body trembled continuously, while the woman across from her kept approaching, placing her hands on Chu Qingqiu's shoulders and smugly nestling into her embrace.

"The Divine Venerable seems to be saying some name." Liu Wenzhu anxiously was about to go out.

"Ning... Ning Fu..." Ning Fuyi read her lip movements and immediately widened her eyes. Her body flashed, and she leaped out the door half a step before Liu Wenzhu, not caring about alerting anyone, and burst through the door.

But just as she entered, Chu Qingqiu, who had seemed lost just moments before, suddenly opened her eyes with an unusually fierce look. Before Ning Fuyi could see clearly what she did, the woman groaned, rolled her eyes, and gracefully collapsed.

Liu Wenzhu, who arrived right after, quickly caught the woman with sharp reflexes, preventing her from making any noise.

Ning Fuyi almost couldn't stop in time and nearly crashed into Chu Qingqiu. She hurriedly reached out to brace against the wall, stopping just in front of Chu Qingqiu, her nose tip brushing past Chu Qingqiu's hair and leaving behind a faint cold fragrance.

"Divine... Divine Venerable." Ning Fuyi said in a daze.

Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her. She still seemed to be looking at the earlier illusion, her peach blossom eyes red like peach blossoms, her pupils seeming to have moisture in them, sparkling like crystals in the lamplight.

She leaned weakly against the wall, fallen hair covering half her face, her expression like snow blown into mud - cold and broken.

After an unknown amount of time, she finally withdrew her gaze and slowly stood up straight.

"That girl is underground." Chu Qingqiu's voice revealed no emotion. "Some immortal arts don't work on her because she's from the fox clan. But when she pulled me into her illusion, she also exposed her memories."

"Fox clan?" Liu Wenzhu asked in surprise.

While Ning Fuyi breathed a sigh of relief, she looked down at the woman's appearance. Indeed, being able to captivate people's hearts with just a pair of eyes - only the fox clan could do such a thing.

Between heaven and earth, aside from the ancient divine clans, there were only five clans or five realms: the Immortal Realm, Demon Realm, Mortal World, Underworld, and Spirit Clan. Among them, the Spirit Clan was considered the most "lowly" - mostly formed from worldly creatures through cultivation, with weak magical power. They were often used as slaves in the past and viewed as inferior beings. But after the Six Great Sects came to power, they jointly issued orders forbidding the private capture of Spirit Clan members, so such phenomena became rare.

"I remember Elder Pingyao saying that many Spirit Clan members are spirits formed from precious medicinal herbs. For cultivators, they're great supplements that can improve cultivation, so some people still secretly invade their homes and hunt them for consumption. That's why there are fewer and fewer Spirit Clan members remaining." Liu Wenzhu said softly. "I've never seen any from childhood to adulthood. I didn't expect to encounter them here."

Chu Qingqiu suddenly reached out, and white silk flew from her sleeves, wrapping the woman up like a dumpling. She also covered her face, especially those eyes, which were covered layer upon layer.

Chu Qingqiu was also vengeful, Ning Fuyi thought.

But she didn't know why in times of danger, Chu Qingqiu had called out her name.

"Let's go." Chu Qingqiu said. She gently raised her hand, and her white jade flute White Bone returned to her hand.

Neither Ning Fuyi nor Liu Wenzhu spoke again, but quietly walked out the door. When passing a brightly lit room, Ning Fuyi even poked through the door paper to look at the unspeakable scenes for a few moments.

She hadn't been looking long when the back of her head was slapped, making her quickly straighten up in pain.

"Old fogey." She muttered again softly.

After the woman was knocked unconscious, they saw no one else along the way. They returned to the first floor with the huge platform. Chu Qingqiu walked onto the high platform and tapped the ground three times with White Bone. The landscape painting behind them seemed to come alive, with water beginning to flow inside.

Chu Qingqiu took the lead and stepped into it. Watching her figure disappear, Ning Fuyi pulled Liu Wenzhu along and followed suit.

It was instantly like having a basin of cold water poured over them - bone-chillingly cold. Ning Fuyi shivered, and when she opened her eyes again, she was already stepping on winding stone stairs leading downward.

"It's actually so deep down here." Liu Wenzhu said carefully. These stairs were like a snail shell, spiraling down, getting darker the further they went.

The three walked slowly. After walking for an unknown amount of time, they finally stepped onto level ground. Before them was pitch darkness. Chu Qingqiu flicked her finger, and torches on the surrounding walls lit up one by one, revealing everything underground.

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu both gasped in unison. They saw that the circular underground cellar was densely packed with cages. These iron cages were the same as those that had once held spirit beasts - made of Dark Iron⁶, with dried bloodstains on the bars.

Most cages were empty, but some contained things. Ning Fuyi frowned and quickly walked forward, shocked to discover that inside were living people.

As if a valve had been opened, those people all began crying and wailing, their voices so shrill they made one's heart tremble.

"These are all Spirit Clan members!" Liu Wenzhu's tears nearly fell. "Who is so vicious as to imprison them here!"

As soon as she finished speaking, Ning Fuyi suddenly sensed something wrong and shouted a warning. Then immortal power surged from her hands, deflecting an arrow aimed at Liu Wenzhu. The three immediately turned to face a dark corner.

"Who's there? Show yourself!" Chu Qingqiu's fingertips turned, and White Bone transformed into a long staff in her palm, glowing faintly.

Rustling footsteps sounded as a thin, shriveled man slowly emerged from the shadows - the same person they had seen on the first floor. He had completely changed from his earlier submissive manner, like a different person entirely, even the scar on his head radiating malice.

He was gripping a delicate young girl in his hands. Her face couldn't be seen clearly, but from her slender figure, she should be the Man'er the woman had mentioned.

"Who are you people?" The man's voice was hoarse. He held a poison-tipped knife in his hand, pressing it against the girl's throat. "What business do you have breaking into my Ruyan Tower?"

"Capturing and trafficking Spirit Clan members is punishable by immediate execution by the Six Great Sects." Chu Qingqiu spoke, her voice echoing in the cellar.

"Bah! I'm catching some beasts - what law am I breaking!" The man pressed the knife closer. "I don't care who you are. Leave Ruyan Tower immediately, or this little girl's life will be on your heads!"

"Bah!" Ning Fuyi flew into a rage upon hearing this. No one in this lifetime could threaten her, Ning Fuyi. So regardless of the girl in the man's hands, she immediately sent forth a surge of immortal power. The man had never seen someone who cared so little for the life of the person they were supposed to save. In his panic, the knife tip slid along the girl's throat.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu scolded upon seeing this. Several white silks shot out from behind her, snatching the girl from the man's hands with lightning speed. The remaining white silks were about to take his life when another person descended from above, hands formed into claws, slashing the white silks and protecting the man behind them.

The newcomer was the fox clan woman from earlier. She now looked completely crazed, manifesting nine tails that surged toward the girl lying on the ground like whips, trying to recapture her.

But her movements weren't as fast as Chu Qingqiu's. In an instant, white light blocked her actions. At the same time, the girl lying on the ground suddenly awakened. Frightened by the scene before her, she crawled up using her hands and feet and ran toward Ning Fuyi and the others in terror.

That flower-like jade face was completely exposed before Ning Fuyi at the same time the girl crashed into her embrace, tightly hugging Ning Fuyi's waist.

Ning Fuyi stared at her features and was momentarily speechless.

Author's Notes:

Chu Qingqiu: Little girl, this is ungrateful behavior.

Sorry, there was a little accident and I almost didn't finish writing. Posted a bit late (sliding on knees) (kowtowing) (kowtowing again)

Footnotes:

1. **Innocent one (雏儿)** - Literally means "chick" or "fledgling," referring to someone sexually inexperienced
 2. **Fox clan (狐族)** - Mythical fox spirits known for their seductive abilities and illusion magic
 3. **Emotionless way (无情道)** - A cultivation path that requires severing all emotional attachments
 4. **Six senses (六根清净)** - Buddhist concept referring to purification of the six sense organs (eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, mind)
 5. **Emei spike (峨眉刺)** - A traditional Chinese weapon, thin spikes used for stabbing
 6. **Dark Iron (玄铁)** - A mystical metal often used in cultivation novels, known for its strength and ability to contain spiritual energy
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Author's Notes: This chapter reveals the dark truth behind Ruyan Tower - it's a front for trafficking Spirit Clan members. The rescue attempt leads to a shocking discovery about the identity of the rescued girl that leaves Ning Fuyi speechless.